

Footprints of FAITH

A traveller with mixed identity brings out the conflict between Islam and modernity

By Sunil Sethi



STRANGER TO HISTORY: A SON'S JOURNEY THROUGH ISLAMIC LANDS
by AATISH TASEER
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Somewhere mid-point in this memoir and travelogue, the author, as a 17-year-old at a boarding school in south India, feels impelled to make an important telephone call. For anyone in his place the call would be routine, even customary. It is a call to his father. But Aatish Taseer doesn't know where, or how, to find him. His father disappeared when he was two, leaving him in the custody of his mother in Delhi and with two tangible memories: a biography of the hanged Pakistani leader Zulfikar Ali Bhutto that he'd written and a couple of photographs in a silver frame. When, finally, through a combination of quick thinking, subterfuge and

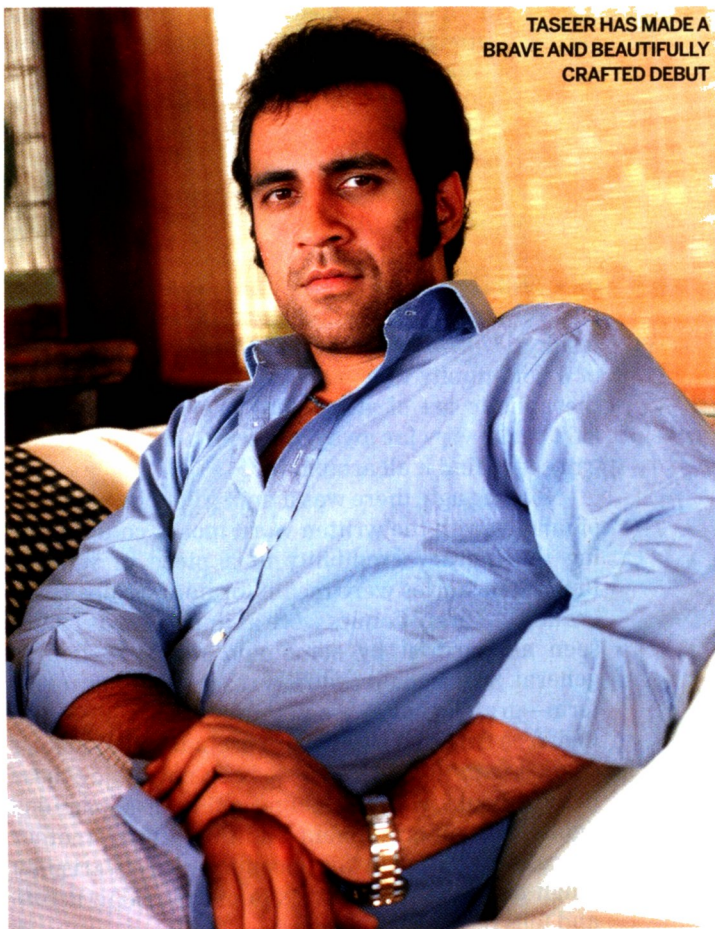
gentle goading by the school therapist, he makes the most important call of his life to track down his father in Lahore, he is met with a dissembling response. And the next day, when he tries to connect with the voice he desperately wants to hear, he finds his father impersonating a servant in Urdu to say that the master is out.

The curious case of Aatish Taseer is well-established: father, the Pakistani politician Salmaan Taseer, now governor of Punjab; mother the Indian columnist Tavleen Singh; and their short-lived affair in the early 1980s ruptured by diverging interests against the backdrop of a tortuous India-Pakistan relationship. Brought up in a supportive Sikh family, Aatish has the sense of being Muslim: "but it was a very small sense... if there was a link between the missing foreskin and my missing father, it was too difficult to grasp."

Accounts by children in search of a biological parent are not uncommon, and they often appear like knitting to a pattern, to be safely docketed under the "Lost & Found" label. On the sub-continent, lost-and-found stories are a running narrative of families torn apart by the Partition. But it is what Taseer makes of his double quest—the search for his father and of his Muslim identity—that makes his journey compellingly personal and political, a vigorously observed account of the inner and outer worlds.

Following school, he finds himself an education and a career as a journalist, but the pursuit of his father stays. After writing the cover story for a magazine on the lives of young British Pakistanis in suburban Leeds, many of whom were found guilty of bombing London's buses and trains in 2005, he proudly posts the dispatch to his father. Back comes a sharp reprimand: "By projecting yourself as an 'Indian Pakistani' you are giving this insulting propaganda credibility as if it is from one who knows all." Lost paternity, ambiguous identity: the son's journey has just begun.

Taseer describes it in a wide arc of travel, through five Islamic countries, of what it means to be a young Muslim, in a tenuous "small sense" or otherwise. In Syria, he is caught in the maelstrom over the Prophet's cartoons and a visceral hatred of America and Israel, and in Turkey, in a reactive Islam rearing its head against decades of



TASEER HAS MADE A BRAVE AND BEAUTIFULLY CRAFTED DEBUT

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